The humanist focus on feelings and experiences, rather than deeds, transformed art. Wordsworth, Dostoevsky, Dickens and Zola cared little for brave knights and derring-do, and instead described how ordinary people and housewives felt. Some people believe that Joyce's *Ulysses* represents the apogee of this modern focus on the inner life rather than external actions – in 260,000 words Joyce describes a single day in the life of the Dubliners Stephen Dedalus and Leopold Bloom, who over the course of the day do…well, nothing much at all.

Few people have actually read all of *Ulysses*, but the same principles underpin much of our popular culture too. In the United States, the series *Survivor* is often credited (or blamed) for turning reality shows into a craze. *Survivor* was the first reality show to make it to the top of the Nielsen ratings, and in 2007 *Time* magazine listed it among the hundred greatest TV shows of all time.[5] In each season, twenty contenders in minimal swimsuits are isolated on some tropical island. They have to face all kinds of challenges, and each episode they vote out one of their members. The last one left takes home $1 million.

Audiences in Homeric Greece, in the Roman Empire or in medieval Europe would have found the idea familiar and highly attractive. Twenty challengers go in – only one hero comes out. 'Wonderful!' a Homeric prince, a Roman patrician or a crusader knight would have thought to himself as he sat down to watch. 'Surely we are about to see amazing adventures, life-and-death battles and incomparable acts of heroism and betrayal. The warriors will probably stab each other in the back, or spill their entrails for all to see.'

What a disappointment! The back-stabbing and entrails-spilling remain just a metaphor. Each episode lasts about an hour. Out of that, fifteen minutes are taken up by commercials for toothpaste, shampoo and cereals. Five minutes are dedicated to incredibly childish challenges, such as who can throw the most coconuts into a hoop, or who can eat the largest number of bugs in one minute. The rest of the time the 'heroes' just talk about their feelings! He said she said, and I felt this and I felt that. If a crusader knight had really sat down to watch *Survivor*, he would probably have